

The Sacrament of Penance

By Dn Yonnas · Sacraments · Youth & Young Adults

Summary

Penance is the sacrament by which a baptized believer who has fallen into sin returns to God through sincere repentance, confession before a priest, and absolution. The lesson covers why we need penance, how Christ instituted it, how it works, how to prepare for confession, and the assurance that all sins sincerely repented can be forgiven.

Lesson Objectives

- Define the Sacrament of Penance and its purpose
- Show from Scripture how Christ gave the authority to bind and loose
- Learn how to prepare for confession and why it precedes Holy Communion

Key Bible Verses

Matthew 16:19 — "whatever you bind on earth shall be bound in heaven"

Malachi 3:7 — "Return to Me, and I will return to you"

Isaiah 1:18 — "Though your sins are like scarlet, they shall be as white as snow"

Main Teaching Points

- Sin separates us from God — as Adam and Eve hid in the Garden
- Penance restores the relationship, like the Prodigal Son returning to the Father
- Christ instituted penance, giving the apostles authority to bind and loose
- The penitent repents, resolves to change, confesses to a priest, and receives absolution
- We examine our conscience and pray Psalm 139:23 before confession
- Penance prepares us to receive Holy Communion worthily (1 Cor 11:28)

Key Terms

- **Absolution** — The loosing of sins through the priest's prayer, by the authority Christ gave (Matt 16:19; John 20:23).
- **Confession** — Naming our sins sincerely before God in the presence of His priest.
- **Epitimia** — A spiritual discipline given by the confessor — medicine for healing, not punishment.
- **Father Confessor (Yenef Abat)** — The priest who hears confession and shepherds the soul's healing.

Discussion & Reflection

- Why does confession before a priest help us more than confessing 'privately' alone?
- What is the difference between feeling guilty and true repentance?
- Why must we examine ourselves before approaching the Eucharist?